

Brazil



Covering almost half of South America, Brazil is the site of the world's largest and ecologically most important rainforest. The country has immense natural and economic resources.



GEOGRAPHY

Rainforest grows around the massive Amazon River and its delta, covering almost half of Brazil's total land area. Apart from the basin of the River Plate to the south, the rest of the country consists of highlands. The mountainous east is part-forested and part-desert. The coastal plain in the southeast has swampy areas. The Atlantic coastline is 1240 miles (2000 km) long.



CLIMATE

Brazil's share of the Amazon Basin has a model tropical equatorial climate, with high temperatures and rainfall all year round. The Brazilian plateau has far greater seasonal variation. The dry northeast suffers frequent droughts, though coastal regions are occasionally flooded by bouts of torrential rain. The south has hot summers and cool winters.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Diverse population includes Amerindians, black people of African descent, European immigrants, and those of mixed race. Amerindians suffer prejudice from most other groups. Shanty towns in the cities attract poor migrants from the northeast. Urban crime, violent land disputes, and unchecked development in Amazonia tarnish Brazil's image as a modern nation. Catholicism and the family unit remain strong.



THE ECONOMY

Dominant regional economy. Huge potential for growth based on abundant natural resources. A leading exporter of coffee, sugar, and orange juice. Social tension threatens stability. Infrastructure needs investment.

FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Federative Rep. of Brazil

DATE OF FORMATION: 1822

CAPITAL: Brasília

POPULATION: 194 million

TOTAL AREA: 3,286,470 sq. miles
(8,511,965 sq. km)

DENSITY: 59 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Portuguese*, German, Italian, Spanish, Polish, Japanese, other

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 74%, Protestant 15%, atheist 7%, other 4%

ETHNIC MIX: White 54%, Mixed race 38%, Black 6%, other 2%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Real = 100 centavos